

Ai Niitsu is a Team Director at the RIKEN Center for Integrative Medical Sciences in Japan. She obtained her Ph.D. in Chemistry from the University of Tokyo in 2012 and undertook postdoctoral research under the supervision of Prof. Dek Woolfson at the University of Bristol, UK. She joined RIKEN in 2016, working with Dr Yuji Sugita before establishing her own research team in 2024. Her research focuses on the rational and de novo design of proteins and peptides to understand and control biomolecular dynamics and signal transduction, with a particular emphasis on membrane proteins. In 2025, she was distinguished as one of the ten recipients of the NICE STEP Researchers 2025 award by the National Institute of Science and Technology Policy (NISTEP), MEXT, Japan